

Bling H_2O luxury bottled water (Opposite page); Saratoga natural spring water from the foothills of the Adirondacks mountain range in North America (Above)

THE NEW VINTAGE

The shift from tap to terroir is best exemplified by The Inn at Little Washington in Virginia. In December 2024, the Michelin-starred destination debuted a menu led by chef Patrick O'Connell and The Inn's water sommelier Cameron Smith. Selections range from a $9 Italian Ferrarelle to a $95 bottle of Berg, hand-harvested from 15,000-year-old Canadian icebergs. "Guests are blown away," says Smith. "Most have never had any choice beyond the standard still, sparkling or tap. They are fascinated to meet a certified water sommelier and learn about each water's source—whether it's a spring, artesian well, glacier, rainwater, or even mist and to hear about its geological journey that gives it its unique mineral profile. For many, this level of detail and storytelling about something as fundamental as water is an entirely new world."

In late 2025, Cheshire's La Popote became one of the first in the UK to debut a dedicated water menu. Curated by sommelier Doran Binder to complement chef Joseph Rawlins' French cuisine, the list features fine water detailed by origin, mineral profile, and mouthfeel. To preserve these nuances, the water is served with deliberate ceremony—poured into elegant stemware at room temperature. While still a novelty in the UK, the concept was pioneered over a decade ago in California by renowned water sommelier Martin Riese who launched a 44-page guide at Los Angeles' Ray's and Stark Bar in 2013. His debut featured 20 varieties from 10 countries,